

Russian Federation



A vast nation, stretching across Europe and Asia, with a long history of authoritarian rule.

862 **Rurik the Viking** establishes order among quarreling Slav tribes in Novgorod. According to legend, he is invited to rule over them. Varangians—the Swedish Vikings—use the river routes of the Dnieper for trade as far afield as Constantinople, the Byzantine Empire and the Middle East.

882 **Oleg, Rurik's successor**, occupies Kiev, and further descendants of Rurik, including the regent Olga, who around 955 is baptized in Constantinople, unite the Kievan and Novgorod states.

988 **Prince Vladimir, Olga's grandson**, is baptized and converts the Kievan lands (Rus) to Eastern Orthodox Christianity. He marries Anne, sister of the Byzantine Emperor Basil II.

1237–40 **The Mongols (Tatars)** conquer Rus, and rule for nearly 250 years. The polity of Rus has disintegrated since its golden age under Prince Yaroslav the Wise into quarreling princedoms ruled by members of the same dynasty.

1328 **The Tatar Khan** gives Ivan Kalita, prince of Moscow, the right of seniority over the other Russian princes and Moscow emerges as the most powerful Russian princedom. In 1326 the Metropolitan of Russia moves his seat to Moscow, after residing in Vladimir since the fall of Kiev.

1453 **Constantinople, the center** of eastern Christianity, falls to the Turks. Moscow comes to regard itself as Constantinople's successor, "the third Rome" and center of Orthodox Christianity. Ivan III of Muscovy marries the niece of the last Byzantine emperor and calls himself Czar (a corruption of the Latin Caesar). When Novgorod falls to Moscow in 1471, the Russian princedoms are united.

1480 **Ivan III ceases to** pay tribute to the Tatars, making Muscovy an independent although isolated nation.

Imperial power

The Winter Palace in St. Petersburg was completed in 1762 for Catherine the Great. The assault on the palace by Bolshevik forces in 1917 was one of the seminal events of the Russian Revolution.



Ivan III

Grand Prince of Moscow from 1462, Ivan assumed the title Sovereign of all Russia in 1493, and, in marrying a Byzantine princess, acquired the emblem of the two-headed eagle of Byzantium.

1501 **Ivan III invades** Poland–Lithuania. His successor Vasili II gains Smolensk in 1514.

1533 **Ivan IV** (Ivan Grozny or "the Terrible"), grandson of Ivan III, ascends to the throne at the age of three. His reign effectively begins in 1547, when he becomes the first ruler to be crowned czar. He conquers the Khanates of Kazan in 1552 and of Astrakhan in 1556, steadily expanding Russian territory south toward the Caspian and Black seas and opening up trade routes down the Volga and across the Urals to Central Asia. In 1565 he makes much of northern Russia around Novgorod his own personal state (the Oprichnina), bringing him into conflict with the boyars (high noblemen). He seizes the boyars' lands and hands them to a service nobility dependent on the czar. The remaining free peasant communities are all destroyed. The second half of his rule is marked by repression of the boyars, many of whom are executed for treason.

1571 **Crimean Tatars** sack Moscow in the civil war caused by Ivan's policy of forced russification and Christianization.

1581 **Russian conquest** of Siberia begins under Ivan IV. Fur trappers and traders establish a series of trading fairs in southern Siberia; the trade in furs is heavily regulated, and brings in great wealth.

1582 **Poland and Sweden** repel Russia's attempt to gain a Baltic coastline.

1595 **Russian control** over eastern Ukraine is secured.

1598 **Boris Godunov**, brother-in-law of Feodor I, Ivan's son, is elected czar. On his death in 1605, the "Time of Troubles" begins—a turbulent period resulting from the lack of a natural successor to the throne, a rise in social discontent, and war in Russia sparked by Swedish and Polish aggression that decimates western Russia.

1611 **Ingria and Karelia** are ceded to Sweden, which occupies the Novgorod area until 1617, when Russia abandons claims to Estonia and Livonia (Latvia) by the Treaty of Stolbovo.

1613 **Mikhail Romanov, first** of the dynasty that will rule until 1917, is elected czar after the Poles are driven out of Moscow. He is succeeded in 1645 by his son Alexis.

1637 **Russian explorers** reach the Pacific coast of Siberia.

1655 **Russian forts are built** along the Amur river inside Manchu China. By the 1689 Treaty of Nerchinsk, Russia abandons the vast region north of the Amur river to Manchu China.

1667 **Poland cedes** Smolensk and Kiev to Russia.

1670 **The first of a series** of rebellions shake Russian rule in the south, including the Cossack rebellion led by Stenka Razin ("Little Stephen") which is eventually crushed. Uprisings by Don and Dnieper Cossacks against Polish rule allow Russia to extend its territories south to the Ottoman client state of the Crimea and west to Kiev.

1682 **Peter I** (Peter the Great) becomes czar after a confused period of palace coups and struggles for the succession. Initially he is joint czar with his mentally challenged half-brother Ivan V under the regency of their elder sister, Sophia. He becomes sole czar in 1696. Peter introduces, by force where necessary, Western culture, customs, education, economy, and government to Russia. In 1703 he founds St. Petersburg, which in 1712 becomes the Russian capital. War with Sweden prompts Peter to create Russia's first navy and its first modern army. He dies in 1725, having had his son

executed and established the right of the sovereign to choose a successor. Palace coups establish or end the next eight reigns until 1801.

1696 **Peter the Great** takes the strategic fortress of Azov from the Ottomans, gaining Russian access to the Black Sea for the first time. Defeat by the Ottomans at Prut in the Balkans in 1711 ends plans to expand into the Balkans and Russia is forced to hand Azov back, only regaining it in 1736.

1700–21 **Great Northern War** between Sweden and those, including Russia, seeking to deprive it of its Baltic and north German territories. Russia is defeated by Sweden at Narva in 1700 but defeats the Swedish king, Charles XII, at Poltava in Ukraine in 1709. The treaties that end the war in 1720–21 give Russia control over Estonia, Ingria, and part of Karelia, giving it access to the Baltic Sea.

1712 **Seat of government** moved from Moscow to St. Petersburg.

1723–32 **Russia occupies** the Persian-held south and west coasts of the Caspian Sea, before being forced out by the Persians under Nadir Shah.

"I shall be an autocrat: that's my trade. **And the good Lord** will forgive me: **that's his.**"

ATTRIBUTED TO CATHERINE THE GREAT
(REIGNED 1762–96)

1762 **The German-born** Catherine II (Catherine the Great) becomes empress after leading a palace coup against her husband, Peter III. Her reign extends Russian territory at the expense of Poland and Turkey, and although initially the ideas of the Enlightenment are welcomed in the Russian state, they are suppressed after the French Revolution of 1789. Catherine dies in 1796.

1772 **First partition of Poland** with Austria and Prussia brings gains of territory west of Smolensk. The second partition in 1793 brings west Ukraine; the third in 1795 brings Lithuania and most of Belarussia.

1773 **The Don Cossack** Emelian Pugachev leads a rebellion against the Russian feudal system, and takes control of a large part of eastern Russia. He is defeated the following year.

